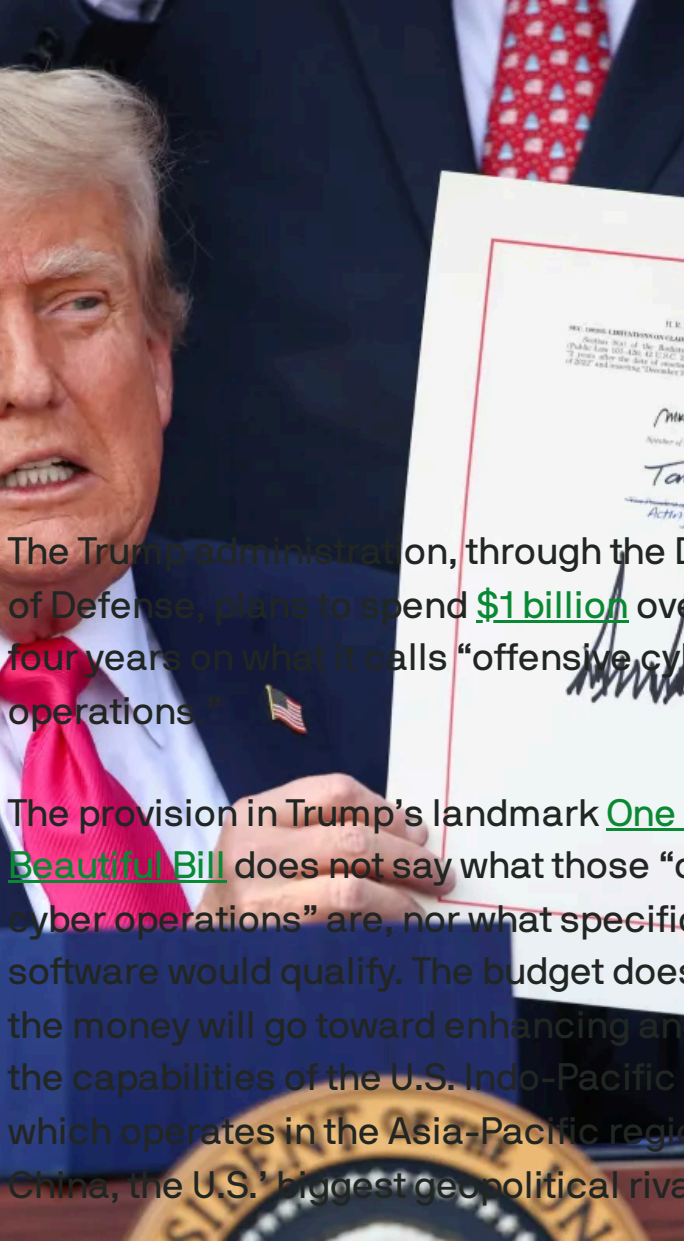


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Trump administration to spend \$1 billion on 'offensive' hacking operations



Lorenzo Franceschi-
Bicchierai

— 11:45 AM PDT · July 14,
2025

The Trump administration, through the Department of Defense, plans to spend [\\$1 billion](#) over the next four years on what it calls “offensive cyber operations.”

The provision in Trump’s landmark [One Big Beautiful Bill](#) does not say what those “offensive cyber operations” are, nor what specific tools or software would qualify. The budget does note that the money will go toward enhancing and improving the capabilities of the U.S. Indo-Pacific Command, which operates in the Asia-Pacific region, including China, the U.S.’ biggest geopolitical rival.

IMAGE CREDITS: SAMUEL CORIUM / GETTY IMAGES
The move to spend a billion on cyber comes as the newly passed law also slashed a billion from [the U.S.’ cyber defense budget](#), at a time when the U.S. faces ongoing [cyber threats from China](#).

Sen. Ron Wyden, a Democrat and long-standing member of the Senate Intelligence Committee, said that the provision also comes as the Trump administration cut funding for defensive cybersecurity programs, including [gutting the U.S. cybersecurity agency CISA](#) and [its budget](#). The cuts have been only in part [rolled back](#) after a federal court ruled the firing of 130 employees unlawful.

“The Trump administration has slashed funding for cybersecurity and government technology and left our country wide open to attack by foreign hackers,” Wyden said in an emailed statement to

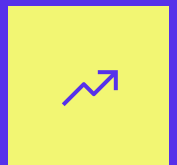
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TechCrunch. “Vastly expanding U.S. government hacking is going to invite retaliation — not just against federal agencies, but also rural hospitals, local governments and private companies who don’t stand a chance against nation-state hackers.”

Offensive cyber operations can describe a wide range of targeted hacks against U.S. adversaries, which include the use of [zero-day](#) exploits — unknown flaws in software that give their operators the ability to hack into a target’s device — or the deployment of spyware, which can be used to steal data from a person.

But these operations can also include more everyday components needed to support those operations, such as setting up the infrastructure needed to carry out cyberattacks, intelligence gathering, such as collecting or buying internet traffic (known as “netflow”), and more.

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Spokespeople from the White House and the Department of Defense acknowledged receipt, but did not respond to a request for comment.

Topics: [big beautiful bill](#) [cybersecurity](#)

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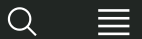
Treasury sanctions Salt Typhoon hacking group



behind breaches of major US telecom firms

Carly Page — 9:10 AM PST · January 17, 2025

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and internet providers, including AT&T and Verizon, to gain access to the private communications of senior U.S. government officials and political figures.

The hackers also hacked into the systems that law enforcement agencies use for court-authorized collection of customer data, potentially accessing sensitive data such as identities of Chinese targets of U.S. surveillance.

In its press release on Friday, OFAC said that Sichuan Juxinhe had “direct involvement in the

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exploitation of these U.S. telecommunication and internet service provider companies.”

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Treasury hackers sanctioned

OFAC also announced sanctions against Yin Kecheng, a cyber actor in Shanghai, which U.S. officials claim was responsible for the [recent widespread hack of the U.S. Treasury](#).

The hack, which took place in late December, saw hackers use a private key stolen from BeyondTrust — a cybersecurity company that provides identity access tech to large organizations and government departments — to gain remote access to certain Treasury employee workstations.

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The cyberattack allowed hackers — [another China state-backed group known as Silk Typhoon](#) — to target various departments within the U.S. Treasury, including its sanctions office.

According to OFAC, Yin Kecheng has been a cyber actor for over a decade and is affiliated with China's Ministry of State Security, an intelligence and security agency responsible for the country's foreign intelligence collection.

U.S. Treasury official Adewale O. Adeyemo said in a statement Friday: "The Treasury Department will continue to use its authorities to hold accountable malicious cyber actors who target the American people, our companies, and the United States government, including those who have targeted the Treasury Department specifically."

Earlier this month, the [U.S. government sanctioned another China-based cybersecurity company](#) over its alleged links to a government-backed hacking group known as Flax Typhoon. The Treasury said the company, Integrity Technology Group, had been involved in "multiple computer intrusion incidents against U.S. victims," including U.S. critical infrastructure.

Topics: [cybersecurity](#) [hacking](#) [salt typhoon](#)

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Carly Page was a Senior Reporter at TechCrunch, where she covered the cybersecurity beat. Prior to that, she had...

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China-backed Volt Typhoon hackers have lurked inside US critical infrastructure for ‘at least five years’

Carly Page — 12:38 PM PST · February 7, 2024

IMAGE CREDITS: IMAGINIMA / GETTY IMAGES

China-backed hackers have maintained access to American critical infrastructure for “at least five years” with the long-term goal of launching “destructive” cyberattacks, a coalition of U.S. intelligence agencies warned on Wednesday.

Volt Typhoon, a state-sponsored group of hackers based in China, has been burrowing into the networks of aviation, rail, mass transit, highway, maritime, pipeline, water and sewage organizations — none of which were named — in a bid to pre-position themselves for destructive cyberattacks, the NSA, CISA and FBI said in [a joint advisory published on Wednesday](#).

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This marks a “strategic shift” in the China-backed hackers’ traditional cyber espionage or intelligence gathering operations, the agencies said, as they instead prepare to disrupt operational technology in the event of a major conflict or crisis.

The release of the advisory, which was co-signed by cybersecurity agencies in the United Kingdom, Australia, Canada and New Zealand, comes a week after [a similar warning](#) from FBI Director Christopher Wray. Speaking during a U.S. House of Representatives committee hearing on cyber threats posed by China, Wray described Volt Typhoon as “the defining threat of our generation” and said the group’s aim is to “disrupt our military’s ability to mobilize” in the early stages of an anticipated conflict over Taiwan, which China claims as its territory.

According to Wednesday’s technical advisory, Volt Typhoon has been exploiting vulnerabilities in routers, firewalls and [VPNs](#) to gain initial access to critical infrastructure across the country. The China-backed hackers typically leveraged stolen administrator credentials to maintain access to these systems, according to the advisory, and in some cases, they have maintained access for “at least five years.”

This access enabled the state-backed hackers to carry out potential disruptions such as “manipulating heating, ventilation, and air conditioning (HVAC) systems in server rooms or disrupting critical energy and water controls, leading to significant infrastructure failures,” the advisory warned. In some cases, Volt Typhoon hackers had the capability to access camera surveillance systems at critical infrastructure facilities — though it’s not clear if they did.

Volt Typhoon also used living-off-the-land techniques, whereby attackers use legitimate tools

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Lorenzo Franceschi-Bicchierai

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and features already present in the target system, to maintain long-term, undiscovered persistence. The hackers also conducted “extensive pre-compromise reconnaissance” in a bid to avoid detection. “For example, in some instances, Volt Typhoon actors may have abstained from using compromised credentials outside of normal working hours to avoid triggering security alerts on abnormal account activities,” the advisory said.



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On a call on Wednesday, senior officials from the U.S. intelligence agencies warned that Volt Typhoon is “not the only Chinese state-backed cyber actors carrying out this type of activity” but did not name the other groups that they had been tracking.

Last week, the FBI and U.S. Department of Justice [announced](#) that they had disrupted the “KV Botnet” run by Volt Typhoon that had compromised hundreds of U.S.-based routers for small businesses and home offices. The FBI said it was able to remove the malware from the hijacked

routers and sever their connection to the Chinese state-sponsored hackers.

According to a May 2023 report [published](#) by Microsoft, Volt Typhoon has been targeting and breaching U.S. critical infrastructure since at least mid-2021.

US disrupts China-backed hacking operation amid warning of threat to American infrastructure



The U.S. government announced Wednesday it had disrupted a China-backed hacking operation targeting U.S. critical infrastructure, amid warnings that Beijing is preparing to cause “real-world harm” to Americans in the event of a future conflict. Speaking during a U.S. House of Representatives committee hearing on cyber threats posed by China, FBI director Christopher Wray told ...

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